

Trojan Room Coffee Pot: The First Webcam

In 1991, the world's first webcam was installed at the computer science department of Cambridge University, broadcasting live images of—the Trojan Room Coffee Pot! Yes, this was done for people working in different parts of the building to view the live status of the coffee pot. This way, they were saved unnecessary trips to the coffee machine.

The camera was installed not on the Internet, but on the local area network, using a video capture card on an Acorn Archimedes—the first general-purpose home computer. The X Window System protocol was



Coffee time!

used for this purpose, and the client software was written by Quentin Stafford-Fraser. Paul Jardetzky wrote the server.

With the emergence of the TCP/IP protocol, Web browsers gained the ability to display images in 1993. Taking advantage of this, this webcam was connected to the Internet in November 1993 and people worldwide could see the status of the "coffee pot." This became a popular landmark on the World Wide Web in those days. Finally, on 22 August 2001, at 0954 UTC, the

camera was switched off, and the pot (which was actually the fourth or fifth since the birth of the webcam) was auctioned on eBay for £3,350 (Rs 2.6 lakh) to Spiegel Online.

Genius Look 315FS comes with drivers for Linux. Similarly, there is Mac support on the Genius VideoCAM Eye and VideoCAM Messenger.

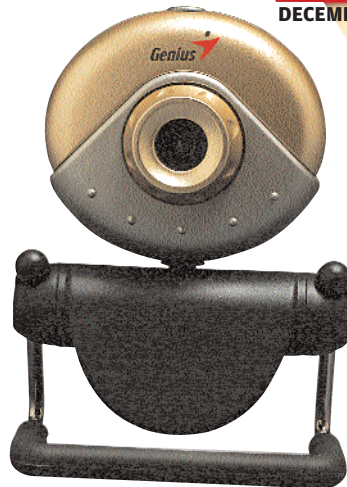
The Logitech QuickCam Chat, IM and Messenger in the PC category and WebCam Notebook in the Notebook category, came with a good software bundle that consisted of the QuickCam software, HP Photosmart Essential—an application for capturing, editing and printing images, and ArcSoft Collage Creator, which is used to create collages of images captured using the webcam. The Creative WebCam Live! was bundled with PhotoManager, an image management software, as well as Advanced VideoFX—an application that lets you perform many visual effects such as face morphs, creating a virtual storm around you, and make you look like you're standing in front of the Statue of Liberty. You can download even more effects for free from Creative's Web site.

The Genius Look 312P and 315FS both came with DDPlayCam, an application that allows you to apply real-time multimedia effects to the live video stream from the webcam.

All the Genius webcams in both categories had bundled similar software for the cam. These programs were named differently but were found to have similar functionalities and interfaces. All of them featured motion sensing

capabilities, thus enabling you to turn them into security cameras. The Microsoft webcams also featured motion sensing and face-tracking software. The face tracking part is performed by digitally panning across the image. A similar kind of digital panning was used in the

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Genius VideoCAM Messenger Golden Eye

Logitech QuickCam for Notebooks Deluxe.

Apart from this, the Logitech QuickCam for Notebooks Deluxe, Messenger and IM supported RightSound technology, a proprietary technology from Logitech that allows you to use the PC speakers instead of the headphones while chatting, and you

don't need to fear the acoustic feedback that is usually heard in such a scenario. A thing to note here is that the RightSound feature has to be supported by the hardware in addition to the software drivers.

Build Quality and Looks

The Microsoft webcams sported the most rugged build quality amongst the PC webcam category. They were also the best-looking cameras, and were elegant enough to be placed on an expensive PC in a great-looking living room. The focusing rings of these cameras were also the smoothest to use.

The Logitech QuickCam Chat, Messenger and IM had looks and build quality that were not much different from each other apart from their colours. A similar trend was seen with the Creative WebCam Vista Pro, Instant, and Live! webcams.

The Genius 315FS, which is shaped like a football, was released to celebrate the football World Cup, which was held earlier this year. The other Genius 312P is designed to resemble a soft-toy dog with the camera embedded in the dog's nose—this will surely be a hit with the kids (and some voyeurs who might hide it among other toys!). The Notebook webcams from Genius also look good.

Performance

Of the PC webcams we tested, none could come close to the Microsoft LifeCam VX-6000's visual quality. This cam not only reproduced colours more faithfully than the others, the image also had better brightness and a well-balanced contrast making it very pleasant to view in any lighting condition. The sharpness of the images, too, was unmatched. Close on its heels was the Creative WebCam Live! with very good visual quality.

The younger sibling of the VX-6000, the Microsoft LifeCam VX-3000, was also good, but the image quality dropped when we tested it in daylight. Still, the quality was much better than most of the others.

A special mention here to the Tech-Com SSD-641-MP—an entry-level webcam. This one has a visual quality that gave some of its more expensive competitors a run for their money.